

years before his father (also named Johann), a prominent dance musician, launched his own orchestra. The young Johann spent much of his childhood at the magnificent Sperl ballroom—made famous by the Congress of Vienna (see [box](#))—or listening to his father’s band rehearse at home.

Johann’s father wanted his oldest boy to train for a career in banking; his mother, however, secretly arranged for him to study violin with the leader of her husband’s orchestra. He also received composition lessons from the future choirmaster of Vienna’s St. Stephen’s Cathedral.

Launching a career

In 1834, Strauss abandoned commercial studies at the Polytechnic Institute in Vienna and applied for permission to give public concerts. He launched his career with a ball at Dommayer’s Casino in October 1844, performing several of his own works, including the Gunstwerber waltz and Herzenslust polka.

Following his father’s death in 1849, Strauss dominated Vienna’s dance scene. He amalgamated his father’s orchestra with his own, attracting a cult following as a composer of brilliant waltzes, polkas, marches, and quadrilles. His long collaboration with Vienna Men’s Choral Association produced such immortal waltzes as The Blue Danube (1867) and Wine, Women, and Song! (1869).

Worldwide fame

Strauss and his orchestra were in great demand overseas and